

ANI

SUSPENSION OF BELIEF
The suspension of 146 MPs united nearly the entire Opposition with Rahul

do so again. The social media cottage industry around him kept up its indie hits all through his parliamentary exile. Carefully curated videos showed him at food stalls in Delhi's Chandni Chowk, with coolies, mechanics, farmers, truck drivers. If his speeches on foreign soil occasionally tempted fate—critics elided the distinction between criticism of government and country—even in the US he managed to hop on to a truck driven by a *desi* to burnish his street cred.

All of it evoked that yatri with mile-long slipstreams of people behind him, enacting an ongoing popular coronation. The Karnataka win in May reinforced that impression, nudging the Opposition to cede a central role to the Congress. Contrary to his image, Rahul worked overtime to coax and cajole probable allies, including difficult ones like Mamata Banerjee and Arvind Kejriwal, as they formed a grand alliance. Its name, the smart wordplay too corny for some but evidently spooky enough for the BJP to briefly consider tweaking the very country's name, was Rahul's idea. His yatra had indeed been quite constitutive of the Discovery of INDIA.

The BJP's dogged vendetta pursuit of Rahul may have boomeranged a bit, giving him the appearance of being the one rival PM Modi is actually wary of

The three recent electoral losses in the heartland came like paradox regained. Yes, Telangana did catch the infection from Karnataka but was the R-value strong enough to make any impression up north? Was the binary the Congress had painted—of inclusiveness, equality and justice, versus an anti-democratic, communal, pro-crony capitalist rival—any good in the 200+ Lok Sabha seats where they go head to head? The Modi regime's relentless pursuit of him may have boomeranged, reinforcing the impression that it was using public institutions, including the judiciary, as tools to silence the Opposition and crush dissent. The mass suspension of 146 Opposition MPs in the winter session, Rahul among them, did no harm to that image. Is all of that a mere storm in a civil society teacup? Does it have any carry in the hard-boiled hinterland, where even Rahul's mainstreaming of the idea of a caste census didn't wash? And so, it's come to a stage where Mamata and Kejriwal have proposed Mallikarjun Kharge's name as a prime ministerial candidate: an implicit veto of Rahul. Now what? If the Congress had its way, some answers would be left unquestioned. ■